Equal Employment Opportunity Innovative Best Practices
Applications (**Fund:** 2026-2028 Equal Employment Opportunity Innovative Best Practices Grant [ID: 2026-2028 EEOIBP])

Produced: Oct 24, 2025, 08:10 AM UTC - By Marrin Thuston

Kern CCD - VR EEO Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program SUBMITTED

Submitted by Bobby Becka on Jul 31, 2025, 09:31 PM UTC

Details

Application Title *

Kern CCD - VR EEO Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program

Application Description

This project will establish a two-year, multi-college Virtual Reality (VR) faculty development and peer mentoring program at Kern Community College District (Kern CCD), to expand equitable access to advanced professional development activities that support faculty career advancement. Using VR technology as an innovative delivery method, the program builds faculty competitiveness for tenure and leadership roles by providing structured training in both emerging instructional technologies and inclusive pedagogy. Modeled after successful community college mentorship programs, this initiative provides "professional advancement opportunities" and strengthens the faculty pipeline "from recruitment to retention" (CCCCO, 2022, p.19).

The program will support faculty across all disciplines in integrating VR into their teaching to enhance student engagement, comprehension, and empathy. Participants will receive advanced training in instructional technology and inclusive teaching methodologies while developing leadership skills. Faculty will document their VR-enhanced lessons using standardized templates to create a shared district-wide digital lesson catalog, extending the program's impact beyond the grant period.

Each year, faculty will complete a structured six-session training series on VR pedagogy, lesson design, and innovative teaching strategies. Faculty will be paired with trained mentors for individualized guidance and receive stipends to support their professional learning. All participants will implement VR-enhanced lessons in their classrooms and present their results at a districtwide showcase. In Year 2, returning faculty may advance into mentor roles, explore VR content creation using tools like Unity, or pursue larger-scale innovations supported by additional stipends.

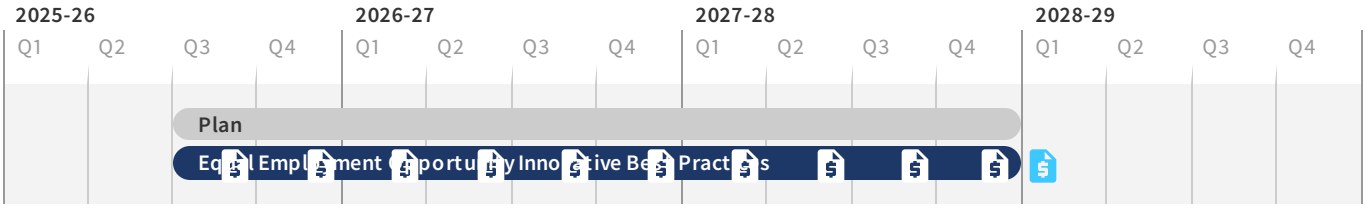
Led jointly by Todd Coston, Associate Vice Chancellor of Planning and Educational Technology, and Rachel Tatro-Duarte, a faculty co-chair with expertise in VR research, the project aligns with Kern CCD's 2025-2030 Strategic Plan and strengthens the current EEO Plan, which focuses primarily on pre-hire activities. By institutionalizing structured post-hire professional development and career advancement opportunities across all three colleges, this program will foster faculty retention, promotion, and leadership development while advancing districtwide instructional equity.

References: CCCCO. (2022). 2022 Equal Employment Opportunity (EEO) / Diversity Best Practices Handbook

Lead Institution

Lead Institution
Kern CCD
Address
2100 Chester Avenue | Bakersfield, | 93301
Community College District
Kern CCD
Website
N/A

Timeline



The start year for this application

2025-26

The start quarter for this application

Q3

The funding year for this application

2025-26

The number of fiscal years this application will span

2 year(s) and 2 quarter(s)

Assurances

2026-2028 EEO IBP Grant Request for Applications

✓ *Read the full RFA in its entirety prior to starting the application. Pay particular attention to the Overall Project Feasibility section. This section will be scored but does not require a written response.*

2026-2028-eeo-ibp-grant-request-for-applications-a11y.pdf

2026-2028-eeo-ibp-grant-request-for-applications-a11y.pdf

Signature Page

✓ *All applicants are required to complete and submit the signature page as part of their application. Endorsement of this document indicates that each signatory has read, reviewed, and can attest to the accuracy of the application submitted on behalf of the applicant listed below. By signing, each endorser affirms that the information provided is complete and truthful to the best of their knowledge.*

The signature page must include four (4) signatures. Please identify and inform all necessary signatories in advance to ensure adequate time for review and completion.

Upload the fully signed document in the designated section of the application portal before the submission deadline. Applications missing any of the four required signatures will be considered incomplete.

cccco-2026-2028-eeo-ibp-grant-signature-page-a11y.pdf

Contacts

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Todd Coston	Project Lead Contact	n/a	tcoston@kccd.edu	(661) 336-5078

System Contacts

Fund Monitor
Marrin Thuston mthuston@cccco.edu

Budget

Budget Summary

Funds Budgeted: $150,000

Budget Total: $150,000

Indirect Funds: $7,496 (5%)

Budget Narrative *

This budget supports a Tier 1, multi-college VR Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program across Kern CCD, focused on equitable technology access and inclusive pedagogy. It funds hardware, software, faculty stipends, and essential support, with future software licensing supported by college general funds.

Year 1 (Jan 1–Jun 30, 2026)

- Object 4000 – Supplies/Equipment $45,000: 20 Meta Quest 3 VR headsets per district (60 total) at $550 each = $33,000; 3 mobile storage/charging carts at $4,000 each = $12,000.
- Object 5000 – Services $3,200: VR environment-building course for four lead faculty ($800 each) to prepare for Year 2 training.
- Object 7000 – Indirect $2,535: 5% of $48,200 direct costs.

Year 2 (Jul 1, 2026–Jun 30, 2027)

- Object 1000 – Certificated Salaries $14,400: 20 faculty stipends ($720 for 24 hours of VR training and curriculum integration).
- Object 3000 – Benefits $3,120: Mandatory withholdings.
- Object 4000 – Supplies/Equipment $45,750: 15 additional VR headsets per district (45 total) = $24,750; 3 mobile carts at $3,000 = $9,000; 6 VR development computers at $2,000 = $12,000.
- Object 5000 – Services $5,040: VR management software for 60 headsets ($7/month).
- Object 7000 – Indirect $3,593: 5% of $68,310 direct costs.

Year 3 (Jul 1, 2027–Jun 30, 2028)

- Object 1000 – Certificated Salaries $18,260: Faculty stipends—10 at $720, 5 at $300, plus 334 hrs of faculty innovation projects at $30/hr ($9,560).
- Object 3000 – Benefits $3,954: Mandatory withholdings.
- Object 5000 – Services $3,780: VR software licensing for 45 headsets ($7/month).
- Object 7000 – Indirect $1,368: 5% of $25,994 direct costs.

This budget supports equitable, scalable VR integration and faculty advancement, with sustainable hardware and software use after the grant period.

Kern CCD: Budget

Expenditure Type	Year	Description	Funds Amount
1000 - Instructional Salaries	2026-27	Faculty Stipends - 20 faculty stipends (4 hours, 6 training sessions, total 24 hours of training at $30/hr) (20 @ $720 each)	$14,400
1000 - Instructional Salaries	2027-28	Faculty Stipends - 10 faculty stipends (4 hours, 6 training sessions, total 24 hours of training at $30/hr) This is the intro training that is the same as the first year. (10 @ $720 each)	$7,200
1000 - Instructional Salaries	2027-28	Faculty Stipends - 5 faculty stipends (5 hours of training on building an environment, 5 hours of developing an experience for their class. Total 10 hours of training at $30/hr) (5 @ $300 each)	$1,500
1000 - Instructional Salaries	2027-28	Faculty Innovation Stipends - This is a pool of hours for faculty stipends to be used for faculty that may already be familiar with VR or already doing VR projects. They could request a stipend to work on a special project or do some additional development of VR experiences. ($30/hr)	$9,560
3000 - Employee Benefits	2026-27	Benefits on faculty stipends	$3,120
3000 - Employee Benefits	2027-28	Benefits on faculty stipends	$3,954
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2025-26	VR headsets for Cerro Coso College (Based on Quest 3 cost - 20 units at $550 each)	$11,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2025-26	VR headsets for Porterville College (Based on Quest 3 cost - 20 units at $550 each)	$11,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2025-26	VR headsets for Bakersfield College (Based on Quest 3 cost - 20 units at $550 each)	$11,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2025-26	Headset Storage Cart - CC (1 at $4,000 each) - Mobile cart with storage for up to 24 headsets.	$4,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2025-26	Headset Storage Cart - PC (1 at $4,000 each) - Mobile cart with storage for up to 24 headsets.	$4,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2025-26	Headset Storage Cart - BC (1 at $4,000 each) - Mobile cart with storage for up to 24 headsets.	$4,000
Totals			**$150,000**

Expenditure Type	Year	Description	Funds Amount
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	Headset Storage Cart - BC (1 at $3,000 each) - Mobile cart with storage for up to 12 headsets.	$3,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	Headset Storage Cart - PC (1 at $3,000 each) - Mobile cart with storage for up to 12 headsets.	$3,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	Headset Storage Cart - CC (1 at $3,000 each) - Mobile cart with storage for up to 12 headsets.	$3,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	VR headsets for Cerro Coso College (Based on Quest 3 cost - 15 units at $550 each)	$8,250
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	VR headsets for Porterville College (Based on Quest 3 cost - 15 units at $550 each)	$8,250
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	VR headsets for Bakersfield College (Based on Quest 3 cost - 15 units at $550 each)	$8,250
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	Development Computer - PC (2 @ $2,000 each - Computers for developing VR content)	$4,000
4000 - Supplies and Materials	2026-27	Development Computer - BC (2 @ $2,000 each - Computers for developing VR content)	$4,000
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2025-26	VR Environment Building Class - This class would be for our lead faculty to take so they can teach something similar to our year two faculty. We are looking at possibly a class at Somerset college. (4 @ $800 each)	$3,200
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2026-27	Development Computer - CC (2 @ $2,000 each - Computers for developing VR content)	$4,000
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2026-27	VR headset management software for pushing out experiences, updates, etc. This is a cost per unit per month. (arborxr.com) - for Cerro Coso (20 units at $7/month for 12 months)	$1,680
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2026-27	VR headset management software for pushing out experiences, updates, etc. This is a cost per unit per month. (arborxr.com) - for Porterville (20 units at $7/month for 12 months)	$1,680
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2026-27	VR headset management software for pushing out experiences, updates, etc. This is a cost per unit per month. (arborxr.com) - for	$1,680
Totals			**$150,000**

Expenditure Type	Year	Description	Funds Amount
		Bakersfield (20 units at $7/month for 12 months)	
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2027-28	VR headset management software for pushing out experiences, updates, etc. This is a cost per unit per month. (arborxr.com) - for Porterville (15 units at $7/month for 12 months)	$1,260
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2027-28	VR headset management software for pushing out experiences, updates, etc. This is a cost per unit per month. (arborxr.com) - for Bakersfield (15 units at $7/month for 12 months)	$1,260
5000 - Other Operating Expenses and Services	2027-28	VR headset management software for pushing out experiences, updates, etc. This is a cost per unit per month. (arborxr.com) - for Cerro Coso (15 units at $7/month for 12 months)	$1,260
Indirect Costs	2025-26	Allowed 5% of Direct Costs	$2,535
Indirect Costs	2026-27	Allowed 5% of Direct Costs	$3,593
Indirect Costs	2027-28	Allowed 5% of Direct Costs	$1,368
Totals			**$150,000**

Application Narrative & Workplan

1. Application Narrative (25 points) *

1.1 Describe the problem or issue regarding EEO programs and practices at your institution. Include relevant demographics and institutional culture, supported by data and evidence of the need. *

The Application Narrative consists of three sections. Applicants are required to respond to Prompts 1 and 3 and choose to respond to Prompt (2a) or (2b). Each response is limited to 5,000 characters, including spaces.
This is the Problem Statement that will be addressed by the workplan below.
The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

At Kern Community College District (Kern CCD), faculty across our three-campus system do not have equal access to technology resources that support instructional innovation and career advancement. Currently, Cerro Coso does not have any VR hardware, Bakersfield has two older VR headsets used primarily for career exploration, and Porterville has approximately 20 older headsets that are used by the Adult Education program. The Kern CCD campuses are seeking to implement advanced technology resources equitably districtwide across all disciplines.

Generally, certain disciplines—particularly in STEM—benefit from targeted federal, state, and foundation funding for technology, equipment, and faculty training, while many non-STEM programs lack similar dedicated investment. As a

result, faculty in humanities, social sciences, arts, and other disciplines often must rely on limited general funds not earmarked for technology upgrades, leaving them at a competitive disadvantage in integrating emerging tools into their teaching.

This funding inequity in technology access contributes to disparities in professional development, innovation in instruction, and career advancement opportunities. The 2022 EEO/Diversity Best Practices Handbook emphasizes that structured professional development and mentorship are critical to building faculty competitiveness for leadership, tenure, and promotion (CCCCO, 2022, p. 19). Without equitable access to advanced instructional technologies, faculty in underfunded disciplines are less able to demonstrate innovation in teaching—a factor increasingly valued in evaluations, tenure decisions, and leadership selection.

National and state programs such as the NSF S-STEM initiative, California's Learning Lab, and foundation partnerships (Aspen Institute, Siemens Foundation) have driven substantial technology investment in STEM programs. However, no equivalent funding streams exist for non-STEM disciplines, perpetuating a structural gap in resources, training, and advancement pathways. This misalignment means that faculty and students in some fields have consistent exposure to cutting-edge tools, while others are left behind.

KCCD currently has very limited VR technology available across its campuses, with no systematic plan to expand access or integrate it into instruction. Our proposed VR mentorship program directly addresses this gap by providing faculty from all disciplines with structured professional development in innovative educational technologies, paired with mentorship to strengthen both technical competencies and leadership skills. This program would level the playing field by extending the benefits of advanced technology training—previously concentrated in select fields—to faculty districtwide.

By creating equitable access to VR-based instructional innovation, we will:

- Equip faculty across disciplines with the tools and skills to integrate emerging technologies into their teaching.
- Support faculty competitiveness for tenure, promotion, and leadership roles.
- Foster districtwide innovation in pedagogy, aligning with KCCD's Strategic Plan commitment to equitable professional development opportunities.

The VR mentorship program addresses a significant gap by equipping faculty with advanced andragogy and pedagogy skills through structured professional development in innovative educational technologies. This program aims to achieve deep faculty engagement with VR, enabling them to explore its applications in teaching, learning, and student engagement. By building structured professional development around emerging technologies like VR, faculty can develop both technical competencies and innovative teaching methodologies, enhancing their readiness and competitiveness for career advancement, tenure, and leadership opportunities. This approach follows successful models in which professional development programs provide the "tools" that empower faculty to integrate emerging technologies effectively into their curriculum (CCCCO, 2022, p. 28).

Just as the West Valley-Mission CCD's Faculty Diversity Internship Program successfully addressed similar professional development needs, its structured training and mentorship significantly advanced participants' careers (33% moved into faculty positions). Similarly, the Kern CCD VR program will demonstrate that technology equity, coupled with mentorship, can bridge advancement gaps across disciplines in a multi-college district by strengthening faculty portfolios, providing opportunities to demonstrate innovation in instruction and leadership opportunities through serving as a mentor to faculty colleagues.

References:

CCCCO. (2022). Equal Employment Opportunity (EEO) / Diversity Best Practices Handbook

NSF. (2023). S-STEM Program Overview
California Learning Lab. (2020). Innovative Learning Initiatives
Aspen Institute. (2018). STEM Workforce Report

1.2 Select one of the following prompts to respond to. *

Applicants are required to select and respond to one of the two prompts: (1) Describe the innovative intervention you wish to pilot. OR (2) Describe the current innovative EEO practice(s) you wish to enhance.

Describe the innovative intervention you wish to pilot.

1.2.1 (Describe the innovative intervention you wish to pilot.) (2a) Describe the innovative intervention you wish to pilot. *

Outline the project goal, purpose, and scope, explaining how the proposed intervention could address the identified issues. Include supporting data and evidence and justify the need for the proposed intervention. Explain how the proposed intervention will address EEO faculty and staff diversity needs at your institution. The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

The Kern CCD project addresses employment practice disparities in professional development access across the district by implementing a comprehensive faculty career advancement program using Virtual Reality (VR) technology as a vehicle for building both technical competencies and leadership skills. This two-year initiative will expand on the groundwork laid in 2025-26, when a district-wide task force began exploring VR as a tool for teaching and engagement.

The core of the project intervention is a structured, cohort-based faculty development program. Each academic year, faculty from Bakersfield College, Cerro Coso Community College, and Porterville College will be invited to participate. The program begins each Fall with a six-part training series (24 hours total) covering:

- Hands-on training with VR hardware and software (e.g., Meta Quest 3 headsets)
- Best practices in VR pedagogy, emphasizing experiential and inclusive learning
- Sample VR lesson plans and strategies for integrating VR into course content
- Collaborative curriculum design and peer problem-solving
- Techniques for using VR to enhance awareness of diversity, equity, and justice
- Career advancement planning, including how to document VR expertise and leadership skills for tenure, promotion, and committee/administrative opportunities

Faculty participants (mentees) will be paired with trained peer mentors who completed the program in a prior cycle or served on the initial task force. Mentor-mentee pairs will collaborate throughout the academic year to design and implement VR-enhanced lessons, culminating in classroom integration each Spring. All faculty will present their outcomes at a districtwide showcase and contribute to a standardized, searchable repository of documented VR lessons ensuring the program's impact extends beyond the grant period.

The Kern CCD project provides equitable access to advanced professional development opportunities across all disciplines, directly supporting EEO goals by ensuring that career advancement is determined by merit, rather than disparities in departmental resources or program-specific offerings. By engaging faculty from all disciplines at all three colleges, this initiative advances EEO goals by:

- Ensuring professional development equity by offering consistent access to cutting-edge technology training for all faculty, regardless of discipline, program size, or available departmental funding
- Supporting a wide range of teaching styles and addressing diverse student learning needs through the integration of innovative tools and strategies
- Promoting inclusive pedagogy through immersive learning experiences that build empathy, cultural competence, and responsiveness to varied student backgrounds
- Expanding leadership and mentoring opportunities that empower faculty from all disciplines to advance professionally and contribute to institutional innovation

In Year 2, returning faculty may advance to mentor roles, deepen their expertise by exploring VR content creation using platforms like Unity, or pilot larger-scale VR projects supported by additional Faculty Innovation Stipends. This tiered approach allows participants to build progressive leadership and technical skills over time, while embedding a sustainable peer-to-peer support structure districtwide.

This innovative intervention directly addresses a significant gap in Kern CCD's EEO Plan, which focuses primarily on pre-hire activities and lacks districtwide post-hire professional development and retention strategies. By institutionalizing structured, cross-college training and mentoring, the program ensures equitable access to advanced instructional technologies and leadership opportunities for all faculty, regardless of discipline or campus size. It is designed to be scalable, sustainable, and impactful -- building a faculty pipeline that is better prepared for career advancement, fostering a culture of inclusive innovation, and closing disparities in professional growth opportunities that have historically disadvantaged faculty at smaller colleges and in under-resourced disciplines.

1.3 Describe your program model, methodology, and evidence supporting your approach to achieving the outlined outcomes. *

The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

This project's faculty-driven mentoring model ensures consistent, districtwide access to advanced instructional technology training, closing professional development gaps that limit faculty career advancement. It institutionalizes structured post-hire professional development opportunities to build faculty retention, leadership opportunities, and equitable access to instructional innovation.

This project's design is informed by both internal expertise and a growing body of national research on the impact of VR in higher education. At the center of the program is a cohort-based faculty development structure that combines immersive VR training with peer mentoring. Each academic year, faculty from Bakersfield College, Cerro Coso College, and Porterville College will be invited to participate in a six-session (24-hour) training series focused on:

- VR hardware and software operations
- Best practices in inclusive and immersive VR pedagogy

- Collaborative lesson design across disciplines
- Strategies for using VR to foster cultural competence, empathy, and equitable student engagement
- Career advancement planning and portfolio development

Participants will be paired with experienced mentors who completed the program in a prior cycle or served on the initial VR task force. These mentor-mentee pairs collaborate throughout the academic year to design and implement VR-enhanced lessons, building both technical and leadership competencies. Faculty will pilot their lessons in the spring semester, document outcomes using standardized templates, and present their work at an annual districtwide showcase.

In Year 2, returning faculty may progress into mentor roles, pursue advanced VR content creation using platforms like Unity, or lead larger-scale VR innovation projects funded through Faculty Innovation Stipends. This tiered approach ensures that faculty continue to deepen their skills while expanding the district's internal leadership and mentoring capacity.

External evidence reinforces this model's potential. Studies at Arizona State University (Dreamscape Learn) and Morehouse College (Metaversity) have shown that immersive VR improves student grades, persistence, and engagement across demographic groups. Faculty lead Rachel Tatro-Duarte, a doctoral candidate in educational leadership, brings extensive expertise in VR-based instruction. Her grounded theory research identified a five-phase model -- Adaptability, Transitionality, Fusion, Enhancement, and Knowledge Transference -- that describes how learners move from orientation to deep empathy and applied insight through immersive VR experiences. This research directly informs the training curriculum and methodology.

Assessment is built into every stage of the model. Faculty will complete pre- and post-training surveys to measure growth in confidence and technology skills, while student feedback will be collected through brief post-lesson surveys. Institutional Effectiveness will track faculty participation, mentor progression, and advancement metrics (e.g., tenure, promotion, committee or administrative appointments) to verify that professional development outcomes translate into career advancement opportunities. All faculty will contribute to a searchable repository of documented VR lesson plans, creating a lasting institutional resource for cross-campus knowledge sharing.

By embedding a sustainable, faculty-led peer mentoring structure, this program eliminates professional development disparities that have historically disadvantaged smaller colleges and under-resourced disciplines. The model demonstrates how post-hire professional development can strengthen faculty pipelines, institutionalize inclusive teaching practices, and ensure that career advancement is determined by merit – not by unequal access to resources or innovation opportunities.

Sources:
Tatro-Duarte, Rachel R.Tatro-Duarte, Rachel R. A Virtual Learning Model for Virtual Reality and Literature. International Conference of the Immersive Learning Research Network (iLRN), 2022. Manuscript.

Arizona State University – Dreamscape Learn"ASU Students Improve Outcomes Using Dreamscape Learn Immersive Biology Curriculum." ASU News, Arizona State University, 2022, https://news.asu.edu/20220202-discoveries-asu-students-improve-outcomes-using-dreamscape-learn-immersive-biology. Accessed July 2025.

VictoryXR and Morehouse College – Metaversity
"Morehouse College Uses VictoryXR's Metaversity for Virtual Reality Learning." VictoryXR, 2022, https://www.victoryxr.com. Accessed July 2025.

2. Workplan: Objectives, Activities & Outcomes (35 points) *

2.1 Project Goals: Identify the major goals to be achieved for the project's expected outcomes. *

The workplan consists of five sections. Each response is limited to 5,000 characters (including spaces). It is the most important section of the application, providing a detailed description of the proposed project's annual activities, timeline, measurable outcomes, deliverables, and responsible individuals. The workplan serves as the foundation for linking all parts of the application, outlining how the project will be carried out to achieve its goals.
Describe the activities and strategies to address the Problem Statement and achieve the Project Goals. The workplan, which serves as the project implementation roadmap, must clearly explain the following: Project Goals, Activities, Measurable Outcomes and Assessment Plan, Timeline, and Responsible Persons.
Project Goals- *For example, if the overall goal is to increase faculty diversity, one project goal could be to develop a diverse candidate pool.*
The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

Workplan: Project Goals

1. Reduce instructional technology access gaps by ensuring that faculty at smaller colleges (Cerro Coso and Porterville) have equal opportunity to experiment with and adopt immersive learning tools. This eliminates employment practice disparities that currently limit career advancement opportunities based on campus assignment rather than merit.
2. Promote inclusive and equity-focused teaching by equipping faculty with VR-based strategies that foster empathy, cultural understanding, and engagement among diverse student populations. This approach simultaneously develops faculty leadership skills in diversity, equity, and inclusion, enhancing qualifications for institutional service and administrative roles.
3. Increase faculty confidence and cross-disciplinary use of VR-based teaching methods at all three Kern CCD colleges. By expanding instructional innovation beyond STEM fields, faculty will build documented technology innovation expertise that strengthens competitiveness for tenure, promotion, and leadership positions.
4. Address a critical gap in Kern CCD's 2024–2027 EEO Plan by adding post-hire professional development and retention strategies. The plan focuses primarily on pre-hiring activities, leaving limited districtwide structures for sustained faculty career advancement once hired. Through the VR Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program, Kern CCD will institutionalize structured post-hire professional development opportunities that enhance instructional innovation, support mentorship and leadership pipelines, and ensure equitable access to advancement opportunities across all three colleges.

2.2 Activities: Describe the activities necessary to achieve each goal. *

For example, for the goal of developing a diverse candidate pool, an activity might include a mentorship program providing on-the-job training and networking opportunities. Explain the strategies to ensure participation in the proposed activities.
The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

To achieve the project's goals, Kern CCD will implement the following activities across two academic years:

Year 1: 2026–2027

- VR Training Curriculum: Faculty participants will complete six 4-hour professional development sessions in Fall 2026, covering topics such as VR hardware use (Oculus Quest 2), best practices in VR pedagogy, collaborative curriculum design, and inclusive VR lesson planning.
- Peer Mentoring: Each participating faculty member will be paired with a trained peer mentor. Mentors will guide mentees in applying VR strategies to their specific course content, provide support, and help troubleshoot challenges.
- Classroom Implementation: In Spring 2027, mentees will pilot VR-enhanced lesson plans in their own classrooms, using one of several possible instructional models (e.g., full-class VR sessions, individual exploration, pre/post-lesson integration).
- End-of-Year Showcase: At the conclusion of the academic year, participants will present their outcomes and lessons learned at a conference-style internal showcase open to faculty and administrators across the district.
- Faculty will document their VR implementations using a standardized template, capturing key pedagogical insights and technical requirements for future faculty use.

Year 2: 2027–2028

- Mentor Program Expansion: The cohort will expand to include new faculty mentees as well as returning participants who wish to deepen their expertise by exploring VR content creation and 3D environment building (e.g., using Unity).
- Advanced VR Design Projects: Faculty exploring VR creation tools will design and test their own interactive experiences in Fall 2027 and implement them in Spring 2028.
- Faculty Innovation Stipends: Faculty will be eligible to apply for additional stipends for larger VR projects that will take beyond the five hours or for larger VR projects. (This will be drawn from a pool of hours set aside as Faculty Innovation Stipends).
- Final Showcase: All participants will present their work at a second end-of-year showcase, with a focus on scalability, equity impact, and next steps for institutionalizing VR-enhanced pedagogy districtwide.
- The project team will organize documented VR lessons into a searchable collection accessible across all three colleges, creating a lasting institutional resource.

2.3 Measurable Outcomes and Assessment Plan: Describe the metrics that will show if activities are achieving the desired results. *

For example, a mentorship program may result in candidates being paired with faculty mentors and gaining guest lecturing opportunities, leading to a certificate of completion. Outline your assessment plan and how it will guide the development of ongoing interventions.
The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

The success of the VR Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program will be evaluated through a focused set of measurable outcomes that reflect equitable access, faculty advancement, instructional innovation, and student impact. These metrics will guide continuous improvement and ensure alignment with Kern CCD's EEO goals by addressing gaps in post-hire professional development and retention opportunities. Key outcome metrics include:

1. Access & Equity Across Colleges/Disciplines: At least 30 faculty trained across all three colleges, with participation proportional to each campus's FTES (±5%) and ≥35% non-STEM representation to ensure districtwide, cross-disciplinary access.

2. Professional Development Effectiveness: ≥75% of participants report increased confidence using VR (pre/post survey) and ≥60% implement at least one VR-enhanced lesson within the grant year.
3. Implementation & Knowledge Sharing: Creation of a searchable repository of ≥35 documented VR lessons, with ≥30% of lessons adopted across campuses (developed at one college, implemented at another).
4. Leadership Pipeline Development: ≥40% of Year-1 participants advance to mentor roles in Year-2 and ≥25% of alumni document new leadership/service (e.g., committee roles, coordinator duties) in professional portfolios.
5. Student Engagement & Equity: In participating sections, ≥70% of students report increased engagement/interest (post-lesson survey), with no engagement gap >10 percentage points between student demographic groups.

Data Collection & Use: Mentor/mentee logs, standardized lesson documentation, participant pre/post surveys, and brief student pulse surveys will be used to track outcomes. The grant leadership team will disaggregate participation and impact data by college, discipline, and faculty demographic group each semester. These findings will be summarized annually and shared to guide program adjustments and inform Kern CCD's broader EEO and professional development strategies.

By focusing on these five key metrics, the program will demonstrate clear progress in closing professional development disparities, strengthening the faculty leadership pipeline, and improving student engagement through innovative, equity-centered instructional practices.

2.4 Timeline: Provide the estimated start and end dates for each activity, ensuring that all activities are completed by the grant's end date of June 30, 2028. *

The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

The VR Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program will span three fiscal years, with the first (a 6-month period) being utilized to purchase supplies and materials so that program staff will have all they need to start activities in the first full/12-month year. Each of the full two (2) academic years will be structured around a Fall training and planning phase followed by Spring classroom implementation and an end-of-year showcase. Below is the projected timeline:

Fiscal Year 1: 2025-2026

- **January 2026 - April 2026:**
    - Purchase materials and supplies

Fiscal Year 2: 2026–2027

- Late August – Late November 2026:
    - Faculty participate in six 4-hour VR training sessions
    - Peer mentor/mentee pairings are established and collaborative lesson planning begins
- Late January – Late April 2027:
    - Faculty implement VR-enhanced lessons in their classrooms

    - Peer mentors provide ongoing support and troubleshoot implementation challenges
- Early May 2027:
    - Faculty showcase their projects, outcomes, and lessons learned at an internal district-wide conference
    - Faculty complete standardized documentation of their VR lesson implementations for resource collection

Year 3: 2027–2028

- Late August – Late November 2027:
    - New cohort begins VR training sessions
    - Returning participants begin work on VR content creation (e.g., Unity)
    - Faculty Innovation Stipend applicants are identified and supported
- Late January – Late April 2028:
    - Advanced VR projects from Faculty Innovation Stipends are piloted and implemented in the classroom
    - Peer mentoring continues throughout the semester
- Early May 2028:
    - Final showcase event is held to present faculty work, share student impact, and discuss future opportunities for scaling VR-enhanced pedagogy
    - Project team compiles and organizes all documented VR lessons into a living, searchable collection for district-wide access that can be continuously updated and expanded with new lessons from future faculty cohorts

This timeline is aligned with the district's academic calendar and supports iterative improvement, reflection, and equity of access across both grant years.

2.5 Responsible Persons: Indicate who will oversee and complete each activity listed. *

The maximum length for this response is 5,000 characters including spaces.

The implementation of this project will be overseen by a collaborative leadership team composed of administrative and faculty personnel, with clearly defined responsibilities:

Year 1: 2026–2027

- VR Training Sessions (Fall 2026):
    - The faculty lead will design and facilitate six 4-hour professional development sessions for participating faculty.
- Mentor/Mentee Pairing and Planning (Fall 2026):
    - The Associate Vice Chancellor of Planning and Educational Technology and the faculty lead will coordinate mentor/mentee pairings and guide initial lesson design.
- VR Lesson Resource Documentation (Spring 2027):

    - Individual faculty participants will document their VR lesson implementations using standardized templates, with mentor support for reflection and compilation into the district's growing VR lesson resource collection.
- Classroom Implementation (Spring 2027):
    - Individual faculty members will implement their VR-enhanced lessons. Designated peer mentors will provide coaching, troubleshooting, and encouragement throughout implementation.
- End-of-Year Showcase (May 2027):All faculty participants will present their work at an internal district-wide showcase to share outcomes and lessons learned.

Year 2: 2027–2028

- New Cohort Training (Fall 2027):The faculty lead will facilitate the training of a new cohort of faculty, including foundational VR pedagogy and technology.
- Advanced Content Creation (Fall 2027):Returning faculty participants will design and test original VR experiences using tools like Unity.
- Faculty Innovation Stipend Support (Fall–Spring):The Associate Vice Chancellor and faculty lead will coordinate the application, selection, and support process for VR Faculty Innovation Stipend projects.
- Classroom Implementation (Spring 2028):Participating faculty will pilot advanced projects or Faculty Innovation Stipend projects in their courses. Peer mentors will continue providing support.
- Final Showcase (May 2028):All faculty participants will present their year-two outcomes and explore next steps for broader institutionalization of immersive, equity-focused teaching.

This shared leadership structure ensures that the program is both administratively supported and faculty-driven, maximizing engagement, relevance, and sustainability.

Management/ Commitment

1. Project Management/ Institutional Commitment (15 points) *

1.1 Describe the staff and individuals responsible for the day-to-day activities of the project, including designing and executing activities, outreach and recruitment, providing interventions, coordinating with partners, and monitoring participants. *

The Project Management and Institutional Commitment section consists of five sections. Each response is limited to 2,500 characters (including spaces).
Project Management*- This also includes submitting required reports and data to the Chancellor's Office.*
The maximum length for this response is 2,500 characters including spaces.

The day-to-day implementation of the VR Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program will be led collaboratively by the faculty lead (co-chair) and the Associate Vice Chancellor of Planning and Educational Technology.

The faculty lead, who has extensive expertise in immersive instructional technologies and whose doctoral research focused on the pedagogical applications of Virtual Reality, will be responsible for designing and delivering all VR training sessions. These include six 4-hour professional development modules offered each Fall, as well as advanced training and support for returning faculty interested in VR development tools such as Unity.

The coordination of peer mentoring activities and classroom implementation logistics will be shared by the Associate Vice Chancellor and faculty lead. Together, they will:

- Match mentor/mentee pairs
- Oversee the collaborative curriculum design process
- Monitor progress through the academic year
- Provide technical and pedagogical support throughout implementation

Additionally, the Associate Vice Chancellor and faculty lead will jointly manage all reporting and evaluation responsibilities, including:

- Tracking faculty participation and demographic representation
- Documenting classroom implementation outcomes
- Coordinating annual showcase events
- Submitting required grant performance and fiscal reports to the Chancellor's Office

This shared leadership model ensures both administrative oversight and deep pedagogical expertise, while also reinforcing the project's core goal: empowering faculty as co-creators of innovation. The structure also provides a strong foundation for continuous improvement, scalability, and alignment with Kern CCD's broader equity and technology initiatives.

1.2 Explain what existing institutional resources and capacity will be utilized and integrated into the project to ensure its success. *

The maximum length for this response is 2,500 characters including spaces.

Kern CCD has already begun laying the foundation for this initiative through its VR Task Force, launching in the 2025-26 academic year. This multi-college group of faculty pioneers is piloting immersive technologies and evaluating their pedagogical applications. The experience and momentum built during this foundational year will serve as a launchpad for full implementation of the VR Faculty Development and Peer Mentoring Program.

To deliver and manage the program effectively, we will leverage several existing districtwide systems and tools:

- Canvas will serve as the learning management system for delivering asynchronous training modules, resource sharing, and reflective assignments tied to each workshop session.
- We also plan to use Cornerstone, hosted by the California Community Colleges Chancellor's Office, to track professional development completion and generate reports on faculty progress.

On the hardware side, we will use existing classroom spaces across the three colleges to run training sessions and demonstrations. For instructional use, we will deploy a mobile VR headset cart that allows sets of Meta Quest 3 devices to be rotated among departments within the three colleges as needed. This approach eliminates the need for permanent VR labs and increases equitable access across the district.

Additionally, Kern CCD's existing professional development structure under the umbrella of the Center for Wellness and Success – including district PD coordinators, event planning systems, and administrative support – will be used to schedule trainings, promote the program, and support showcase events.

Together, these systems provide the operational infrastructure needed to scale the program effectively, without requiring major new investments in space or staffing.

1.3 Identify the executive/administrative sponsor for the project and outline the college resources and personnel that will support and ensure the project's success. *

The maximum length for this response is 2,500 characters including spaces.

This project is strongly supported by Chancellor Steven Bloomberg, who has identified instructional innovation and faculty development as core priorities of the Kern Community College District's 2025–2030 Strategic Plan. The Chancellor has publicly endorsed the expansion of immersive learning technologies such as Virtual Reality (VR) and views this project as a key opportunity to enhance student engagement, close equity gaps, and support inclusive teaching practices across the district.

In addition, the presidents of all three colleges—Bakersfield College, Cerro Coso Community College, and Porterville College—serve as college-level executive sponsors. Each has committed to encouraging broad faculty participation, promoting the mentor program locally, and ensuring that faculty have the institutional flexibility and support needed to engage deeply with this work. Their leadership is especially critical for ensuring equitable implementation across the district's smaller and more rural colleges.

The Chancellor and college presidents will also:

- Participate in program kickoff and showcase events to elevate visibility
- Advocate for continued funding or institutionalization after the grant period
- Help align the program with college-specific equity, innovation, and professional development goals

This strong level of executive sponsorship will help ensure that the project is not only successful during the grant period, but also sustainable and impactful well into the future.

1.4 Describe the role of the Human Resources and Institutional Effectiveness offices in supporting data collection and evaluation. *

Explain how performance measures will be incorporated into the project's evaluation.
The maximum length for this response is 2,500 characters including spaces.

The successful execution of this grant will be supported by close coordination with multiple institutional offices, including Human Resources, Business Services, Institutional Effectiveness, Information Technology and the Grants Office.

- Human Resources will provide critical support by ensuring alignment of the program's outcomes with Kern CCD's EEO Plan. HR will verify that mentor and mentee participation reflects the diversity of the district's workforce and will provide employment demographic data (e.g., employee group, full-/part-time status, and tenure track) when needed. HR will also collaborate with Institutional Effectiveness to evaluate whether participants' engagement in the program correlates with higher rates of retention, promotion, and advancement opportunities across employee groups and campuses.

- The Business Office will provide full grants accounting support, including budget tracking, expenditure validation, and fiscal reporting to the Chancellor's Office. This office has deep experience managing multi-year grant funding and will ensure compliance with all fiscal and procurement regulations.
- The District Grants Office will assist with the initial application submission and continue to provide technical assistance throughout the grant period. This includes help with reporting requirements, documentation, and responding to any modifications or requests from the Chancellor's Office.
- The Information Technology department will provide support for the headsets and will leverage the management tool for updates and pushing out experiences.
- Institutional Effectiveness will collaborate on post-program assessment, including the design and analysis of surveys to measure outcomes such as faculty confidence, technology usage, and student engagement. They will help disaggregate participation and outcome data by college, discipline, and equity group to ensure alignment with EEO performance measures.

Together, these teams will help ensure the project's administrative integrity, fiscal compliance, and data-informed evaluation—enabling the instructional leadership team to focus on delivering an impactful and inclusive professional development experience.

1.5 Provide the college's plan to sustain successful interventions once the grant-funded activities are completed. *

The maximum length for this response is 2,500 characters including spaces.

Kern CCD is committed to sustaining the most impactful elements of this project beyond the 2026-2028 grant period. This initiative is a strategic investment in faculty advancement and equity – not as a short-term pilot – and its design ensures scalability, sustainability, and alignment with the district's EEO and strategic plan priorities.

- Faculty-Led Mentoring Structure: Training faculty as mentors and embedding them across all three colleges creates a districtwide self-sustaining peer mentoring network that can support new cohorts with minimal ongoing administrative cost. This ensures the program's benefits extend well beyond initial participants.
- Reusable Training Resources and Best Practices: All VR training curricula, recorded sessions, standardized lesson templates, and documented best practices will be archived in Canvas and Cornerstone for ongoing access. These resources will allow future faculty to complete training asynchronously or through existing professional development pathways and will serve as a proven framework for inclusive teaching and faculty advancement.
- Mobile Hardware Model: The mobile VR headset cart system guarantees that hardware purchased through this grant remains fully usable across all three colleges. This prevents resource silos and allows smaller colleges to rotate equipment between departments as instructional needs arise.
- Integration into Districtwide PD Infrastructure: The program will be embedded into Kern CCD's professional development infrastructure and annual PD calendars. Future cohorts

will be supported through existing PD budgets, innovation funds, or college-specific funding streams, ensuring institutional commitment beyond the grant term.

- EEO Plan Alignment and Long-Term Impact: This project addresses a documented gap in Kern CCD's current EEO Plan by establishing post-hire professional development and retention strategies districtwide. The mentor network, lesson repository, and documented best practices created through the grant will become permanent features of the district's professional development ecosystem, supporting faculty advancement, retention, and equitable access to career opportunities across all colleges.

Through these sustainability strategies, Kern CCD will preserve the momentum, equity gains, and culture of innovation cultivated during the grant, ensuring that faculty and students continue to benefit for years to come.

2. Overall Project Feasibility (10 points) *

2.1 Applicants are not required to respond to the content in this section (factors 1–4 on pages 13–14 of the RFA). *

Applicants are not required to respond to the content in this section (factors 1–4 on pages 13–14 of the RFA). Instead, please indicate acknowledgment by writing: "I have read this."

I have read this.

Supporting Documents

Document Title	Type	Uploaded	Comment
KernCCD CCCCO EEO IBP rev - signed.pdf	Signature Page	7/31/2025, 9:30:49 PM	N/A

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